Skills and Attributes Required by Football Clubs for Academy Graduates

Examining Psychological, Technical, and Social Factors in the Transition to Professional Football

by

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Abstract

This dissertation investigates the most significant psychological, technical, and external attributes that football clubs consider essential for academy graduates to achieve successful integration into professional football. Despite heavy investment in youth development systems, few players reach first-team level. This study addresses the lack of agreement regarding which exact attributes best predict a successful transition, and how clubs evaluate readiness for senior football.

The most important objectives were: (1) to examine the psychological traits necessary for progressing; (2) to investigate the professional technical competencies needed; and (3) to discover how external pressures like press coverage and social media affect academy graduates

Qualitative methodology was applied. Data was gathered via semi-structured interviews with five football professionals, consisting of coaches, managers, and academy personnel, with direct involvement in the development of young players. Participants were purposefully selected for their direct experience in talent identification, youth progression, and first-team integration within professional football environments. Interviews were recorded, transcribed verbatim, and manually coded for recurring patterns and insights. Interpretation of the data and the identification of prominent themes occurring within participants' accounts were informed using thematic analysis.

The research upheld those psychological qualities—most importantly resilience, flexibility, mental toughness, and coachability—as playing a prominent role in effective transitions. These traits were consistently emphasised across all interviews, regardless of professional role, club tier, or geographic location, highlighting their universal value in youth progression. Technical skills like decision-making, tactical awareness, and performance under pressure were also always brought forward. Additionally, pressures from the outside world like media pressure, parental pressure, and lifestyle difficulties were found to have a high level of influence on the readiness and long-term achievement of a young player

Professional football transition was concluded in this study to demand more than just technical ability. A strong portfolio with psychological maturity and the ability to cope with external pressures demanded. Such findings resonate in football clubs, where talent scouting and academy production need to prioritize mental and emotional preparedness as much as technical ability. The primary limitations are the restricted sample size and specificity towards the English football system. The research can be replicated by larger geographic settings or quantitative variables.

Keywords: academy graduates, psychological characteristics, technical ability, professional football, young people's development, external pressures, thematic analysis.

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CHAPTER I: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Context and Rationale

The transition from an academy to the senior professional level is one of the hardest transitions in the developmental process of an athlete. Every year, thousands of young footballers train hard in academy systems, but only a tiny percentage make this jump to senior football. This transition is not just about technical skills but is shaped with a mix of psychological, physiological, and social factors affecting a player in his readiness for elite football.

The English academy systems are set up on long-term athlete development models that aim to give their youngsters the tools for a successful performance (Cooper, 2021). Yet the whole issue of talent identification and development is often clouded. Irrespective of the advancement in training methods, technology and coaching, many clubs are still having problems converting the best talents from the academy to the first team in a pool of homegrown players who can survive in one of the most ruthless backdrops of professional football (Lundqvist et al., 2024).

Besides the above, with the evolution of football becoming increasingly globalized, commercialized, and scrutinized, a lot of expectation goes beyond the pitch for a young player. Pressure from media must be managed correctly; professionalism when in public and in private life should stay consistent, and handling constantly changing tactical systems and team dynamics, among other things, is what applies to today's academy prospects. These dynamics have made it more difficult to understand what exactly makes one initially an academy graduate truly "first-team ready" (Hamzah et al. 2025).

Therefore, understanding the crucial skills and attributes that clubs look for is vital for both clubs to refine their talent identification and for players, coaches, and analysts in sports to provide more effective support for young athletes. This is a prompt area of research, mostly

because clubs are always going to focus increasingly on the return of investment within youth development as well as compliance provisions regarding home-grown players (Kelly & O'Regan 2021).

1.2 Problem Statement

Although research on talent development is advancing our understanding of the field, there is still no real consensus and clear understanding on which attributes specifically define successful academy graduates. Technical abilities may be the most frequently evaluated skill analysed through training sessions and matches, whilst psychological attributes mental resilience, coach-ability, adaptability, are usually the most difficult to measure yet possibly important in providing a criterion of success years later.

According to the limited studies available, the effects of external factors, such as media hype, parental expectations, and institutional influences, have been rarely examined using scientific methods in relation to the early development of young athletes during this critical phase. This gap reflects a mismatch between the industry's evolving needs, traditional development models, and the real experiences of young players transitioning into senior professional football (Hamzah et al., 2025).

The purpose of this dissertation is to examine which skills, traits, and external factors would matter the most to a football club when it comes to evaluating academy graduates. The study focuses on the beliefs and voices of those individuals who have first-hand experience in the sports: coaches, managers, and performance staff to improve understanding of what it takes to succeed at the highest level of the game.

1.3 Research Aim and Objectives

Aim:

To explore and identify the key skills and attributes required by football clubs for academy graduates to successfully transition into professional football.

Objectives:

1. To analyse the psychological traits that are essential for academy players progressing into the professional environment.
2. To examine the technical competencies clubs, expect from players at the point of transition.
3. To explore the influence external pressures such as media and public scrutiny has on the development and performance of academy graduates.

These objectives will be addressed using a qualitative approach, which draws its insights from interviews with professionals working in professional football academies.

1.4 Research Question

This dissertation is guided by one overarching research question:

"What are the key skills and attributes required by football clubs for academy graduates to successfully transition to the professional level?"

This question encompasses three major themes: psychological readiness, technical ability, and the ability to manage external pressures. By structuring the inquiry in this way, the study aims to develop a comprehensive model of what "readiness" looks like from the perspective of decision-makers within football clubs.

1.5 Structure of the Dissertation

The first of its six chapters opens the case for the study by stating the context, rationale, and significance. It proceeds to state the research problem, objectives, and the central guiding research question. Chapter 2 then provides a critical appraisal of existing academic and industry literatures on several themes, including talent development, psychological profiling in sport, and the transition of academy players to professional football. This chapter highlights the major theoretical perspectives and gaps in existing knowledge. Methodology is outlined in Chapter 3, which includes research philosophy and design, rationale for the use of semi-structured interviews, and thematic analysis process applied to the data collected. In Chapter 4, the results of the study are presented according to the main themes shown from the participant interviews, together with selected quotations that support these themes. To accompany this, Chapter 5 discusses the findings in relation to the existing literature, showing both theoretical implications as well as practical implications and stating the limitations of this study. The work ends in Chapter 6 with a summary of the main findings, an assessment of the study objectives, and recommendations to football clubs, coaches, and future researchers involved in youth player development.

CHAPTER II: LITERATURE REVIEW

The transition from youth academy to senior professional football is an important stage in a player's development and requires psychological hardiness, technical development, and the ability to handle stressful demands. According to Stambulova (2003), such transitions are critical periods in an athlete's career, demanding successful adaptation to new psychological and social challenges to avoid performance decline or dropout. This literature review presents a critical review of the research and theoretical perspectives related to talent development within football academies. Three key areas are the core of this review: (1) psychological traits and their mental skills; (2) technical and tactical competencies; and (3) their external socio-environmental factors affecting talent development in the football academy system, identifying gaps in current literature.

2.1 Theoretical Framework

2.1.1 Developmental Models of Sport Participation (DMSP)

DMSP, as conceptualized by Côté and Co., gives a broad framework about athletes' developmental transitions from the very start of engagement in their sport to long-time elite participation. The model has three phases: sampling years (6-12); specializing years (13-15); and investment years (16 and beyond), stressing the importance that the whole approach was applied in that the foundation is drawn out before focusing on concentrated development (Toms & Jeanes, 2022). It is particularly relevant in football academies, which use similar structured periods of development. Sampling at an early age and specializing later in life would justify multi-sport experiences before focusing entirely on football. Simultaneously, very elite environments, early professionalization can tighten this up because it prematurely puts players into investment (Sweeney, Horan and MacNamara, 2021). Psychological pressure and possibly increased risk of burnout make it incredibly important that adaptive, individual development pathways exist in their academies.

2.1.2 Psychological Skills in Sport

Psychological traits, according to this theoretical framework, are viewed as fundamental enabling factors of performance. Mental skills training (MST) is widely considered to be an essential component in preparing athletes for high-performance environments, Weinberg and Gould (2019) define MST as a structured approach involving self-talk, goal setting, visualisation and relaxation techniques. Skills such as emotional regulation, resilience, concentration, and self-talk strategies help athletes cope with stress and enhance performance variability (Benítez-Sillero et al., 2021). These skills develop informally in the academy environment and become more structured as players get closer to professional levels.

2.2 Psychological Traits for Academy Players

2.2.1 Mental Toughness

The domain of mental toughness has become something of a hallmark in the aspirations of the youth footballer towards reaching first-team status. It involves an ability to concentrate under pressure, in some cases for prolonged periods of time, ability to persist despite adversity, or appropriately dealing with stress and emotions in a regulated manner (McKay et al., 2024). Hyper-competitive scenarios such as a failure, injury recovery, and, in some cases, non-selection are all normal occurrences, with the rationale being that it is an environment where mental toughness assumes even greater importance. In the Premier League and EFL, mental toughness can be theorised by academy managers from the players' behavioral responses to cues pertaining to poor performances, retraining through feedback, or executing under pressure situations (Barraclough et al., 2024). A behavioral approach to training mental toughness is advocated by McKay et al. (2024), whereby clearly defined thinking and systematic routines are embedded in training environments with the clear intention of facilitating these crucial elements in practice.

2.2.2 Confidence and Motivation

The combination of internal motivation and external motivation is especially important to player development. Self-efficacy is associated with confidence and makes things such as goal setting and persistence possible (Saward et al., 2023). Players who are internally motivated are resilient and flexible in their training, while externally motivated players have mostly short-term benefits and sometimes become anxious about performance. Increasingly, coaches are being asked to create environments in which players can develop along self-determined paths, and where mastery is rewarded above outcome (Ashford et al., 2024). Psychological support systems with academies are also vital as a setback such as an injury or deselection can cast serious doubts into any player minds.

2.2.3 Leadership and Team Dynamics

There has been limited research examining leadership and team dynamics, leadership is one of the most important skills that graduates of the academy would have while moving up to first teams. Such players are likely to be more adept when it comes to emotional maturity and socialising with colleagues and teammates and having the ability to thrive during difficult periods offering leadership attributes, therefore improving team dynamics (Barraclough et al., 2024). Such leadership behaviours will earn academy graduates more of such roles, as the captain and peer mentors in academy teams. Cohesion also plays a vital role in development: strong social bonds within academy cohorts contribute to greater psychological well-being, which in turn can enhance athletic performance (Kite et al., 2021)."

2.3 Technical and Tactical Skills

2.3.1 Football Skills and Competencies

Academy graduates' technical attributes remain an important determinant toward any further transition into professional football. The key technical skills are the first touch, range of passing, shooting for accuracy, dribbling, and awareness. They are systematically taught within the

confines of a curriculum that combines deliberate practice with game-like environments and video analysis of games (Ashford et al., 2024). Kite et al. (2021) add that English FA-accredited academy staff insist that technical ability is invariably rated equally to psychological factors that include decision-making and understanding the game---qualities that are seen as the determiners of being ready for first-team action. Tactical adaptability, positional understanding, and spatial awareness all have strong relevance in senior football.

2.3.2 Physical Fitness

Other than technical skills, physical condition is a core requirement. The elite-level football demands sprinting, acceleration, deceleration, and endurance, which all belong to rigorous preparation. Saward et al. (2023) believes that strength and conditioning regimes in academies are now being designed with intensity and load patterns resembling first-team training sessions in order to narrow the performance gap. Poor physical preparation acts as a common entry barrier for gifted academy players who have been unable to cross over. As such, early exposure to first-team conditioning standards has become a core component of elite youth development pathways.

2.4 External Factors

2.4.1 Social Media and Mental Health

With the advent of the digital age, young athletes have become increasingly open to being monitored by social media as this has become a source of psychological injury and trauma. Of these, Instagram and Twitter have created a double-edged sword, offerering visibility while also subjecting individuals to heightened scrutiny and unrealistic expectations. Public feedback (both positive and negative) may shape how academy players, who are themselves still developing a solid athletic identity, see themselves and may even affect what they feel psychologically (Benítez-Sillero et al., 2021). Clubs are beginning to offer workshops in media literacy and mental health to help their athletes better manage their digital profiles and,

therefore, reduce the psychological costs associated with that process. However, there is a need for more empirical studies to better understand the long-term effects of digital exposure during development in athletes.

2.4.2 Pressure and Scrutiny

Media hype and performance stress are considered to be key factors in the development of young players' stress and anxiety. The professionalisations of youth football is paving the way for blurring the lines of adolescence and adulthood, in which players are usually looked at in public at very tender ages (Sweeney et al., 2021). Kite et al. (2021) commented that players able to cope with these pressures are the ones to have successful future careers, highlighting the variability of the coping mechanisms used and further showing a great need for organized psychological support. Family expectations and monetary rewards may also intensify these pressures, this underscores the importance of resilience training and mentorship as essential components of any modern football academy (Uehara et al., 2022).

2.5 Gaps in the Literature

Although there is accumulating research in all the foregoing independent areas of psychological, technical, and environmental dimensions, there is limited evidence on integrative studies that incorporate all three dimensions of interaction. The existing literature is either concerned primarily with psychological profiling (Saward et al., 2023; McKay et al., 2024) or technical development (Ashford et al., 2024) and does not link between the two as it pertains to the lived experiences of academy players. Furthermore, there is often a lack of longitudinal studies, showing that almost always evidence is qualitative rather than quantitative, this makes it difficult to assess cumulative effects over time regarding pressure, training load, and player skill development. External factors (media, family) are acknowledged, but the interaction with complex internal psychological states has yet to receive full attention. This

research will strive to meet the above gap through offering a holistic understanding of the key attributes and challenges facing academy graduates through qualitative inquiry.

2.6 Chapter Conclusion

This literature shows, in some detail, that an easy transition from academy to first-team football is made possible by psychological attributes and technical competence in handling external pressures. While the developmental models have contributed to an approach toward providing an overarching framework, the present dynamic environment of elite football has led to the obvious-styled view that must lead organisations to explore more refined and multidimensional findings regarding player development. The article contributes to the already-existing literature in attempting to explore these aspects through the eyes of practitioners and academy coaches, thereby creating a contribution to both academic and professional debates.

CHAPTER III: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

The chapter describes the research design, the participants, and the methods of data collection and analysis by which information was obtained from football clubs about the skills

and attributes they look for in their academy graduates. The chapter also speaks to the ethical issues, limitations, and justification of the methodological decisions made. The research of this work was based on a qualitative case study design, focusing on semi professional and professional clubs, while data was collected through semi-structured interviews, further analysed using thematic analysis methods.

3.1 Research Design

3.1.1 Qualitative Approach

The qualitative research design is used for the current study topic, that is, about the characteristics considered necessary for academy players to make successful transition into the world of professional football. Whereas the method of qualitative is based on the idea of a much wider applicability through numbers quantified into statistics like quantitative methods, qualitative methodology brings out the particularities in the experiences and practices that exist in specific environments (Siddiqui & Gorard, 2022). The use of a case study is particularly appropriate for this investigation, especially when the boundaries between the context and the phenomenon are not clearly defined. It is well-suited for exploring contemporary phenomena within real-life settings (Yin, 2018). The nature of talent development in football academies is interpersonal, dynamic, and social. Supporting the use of this methodology as it provides the flexibility and depth to meet the researcher objectives of the study.

3.1.2 Justification for Thematic Analysis

Thematic analysis is systematically identifying, organizing, and interpreting patterns of meaning in qualitative data (Braun and Clarke, 2006), suitable for searching for recurrent themes and the values associated with player development that academy staff members align with. It also lends itself to enabling a structured yet flexible interpretive frame of reference

through which participants can express their subjective perspectives to preserve qualitative richness.

3.2 Case Study of Professional Clubs

For a variety of reasons, the case study was carried out at Semi professional and professional clubs. Each time, it evolved through the researcher's prior contacts with the clubs for participant recruitment and data collection. Theoretically, semi professional status clubs serve as an invaluable site for its equal notoriety for producing competitive and resilient players, while operating with fewer resources than high-profile Premier League academy programs. The syllabus represents middle-range English football academies and fills the void of information regarding development in this area. Mostly, this type of research has concentrated mostly on Category 1 academies, so this allows the development of contextual strategies for player development that lean less on their financial capital and more on improved coaching, psychological preparation, and impressive organisational practices.

3.2.1 PIO Framework

To clearly define the scope and direction of this study, a PIO (Population–Interest–Outcome) framework was applied. This structured approach ensures alignment between the research aim, participant selection, and the thematic focus of the study. The table below summarises the key elements of the PIO framework in relation to this dissertation:

Component	Description
Population	Football professionals involved in academy player development (coaches, managers, performance analysts) at semi-professional and professional clubs
Interest	Exploration of key psychological traits, technical skills, and external pressures that influence academy players' transition into professional football
Outcome	Understanding of the attributes clubs value most in academy graduates for successful first-team integration and long-term professional progression

3.3 Participants

3.3.1 Interviewees

Participants were recruited through purposive sampling to ensure that any chosen participant could have the most direct and meaningful involvement with the academy development process. Inclusion criteria for the sampled participants included the following:

- At least 2 years working in a professional football academy.
- Current or former activities in coaching, player development, or general academical managerial activities.
- Some involvement with a semi professional or higher-level club over the past three seasons.

The selected participant group consisted of three coaches, an academy manager, and a player performance analyst/coach. Their roles allowed for diverse perspectives on the various skill sets and attributes needed for transitioning to senior football. Their comments provided insight into formal evaluation criteria and informal developmental interactions.

3.3.2 Sample Size and Generalisability

Interviewed were five participants. Even though this sample size is fairly small, it is in keeping with what would be expected for a qualitative case study design that is about depth rather than large sample sizing. In the view of Siddiqui and Gorard (2022), this constraint is not about statistical generalizability but about transferability-the possibility of findings resonating in a similar context-for qualitative research. This is certainly admitting the limitations of this small sample. The findings might bear a reflection of the specific circumstances regarding the clubs interviewed and might not apply to clubs with different philosophies, developmental resources, or competitive contexts.

3.4 Data Collection

3.4.1 Semi-Structured Interviews

The semi-structured interview was the main data collection method, which creates the type of formal yet flexible discussion within which the subjects could expand upon what they considered important while staying within the framework of pre-set research questions. The interview schedule consists of open-ended questions grouped under three main headings:

1. Psychological characteristics "What mental characteristics do you deem necessary for academy players to excel at the senior level?"
2. Technical skills "What technical or tactical aspects would you expect from a player already ready to play in the first team?"
3. External influences "In what way do external forces, like the media or family expectancies, influence how a player is developing?"

Tests were run on one outsider coach, whom I piloted the interview questions to find out if they made sense or fit the bill of the study. A number of minor modifications took place to improve the flow and ensure consistency with the research's aim.

3.4.2 Interview Process

The interviews have been planned to take place online private meeting rooms, ensuring that confidentiality and the convenience for the interviewees have been taken into account. Interviews were scheduled so as not to coincide with training sessions or preparations for matches, lasting around 20 minutes to 30 minutes on average. With the participants' agreement, these interviews were recorded and transcribed for analysis at a later stage.

3.5 Literature Search and Screening Process

The systematic way was to ascertain relevant academic literature that could inform academic debate concerning the thematic analysis of these interviews. Selected for searching were peer-reviewed documents and reports related to the skills and attributes looked for by football clubs in their academy graduates with a view toward psychological traits, technical skills, and external influences that could affect player development and the transition into professional football.

3.5.1 Database Search Strategy

The searches were performed across several electronic academic databases:

- CINAHL (Cumulative Index to Nursing and Allied Health Literature)
- PsycINFO
- Medline
- SPORTDiscus
- Google Scholar

The search strategy involved the use of Boolean operators with keywords like: “football academy graduates”, “youth football development”, “psychological traits football”, “technical skills in football”, “transition to professional football”, “social media and athletes”, and “elite youth football players.”

3.5.2 Screening and Selection Process

A total of 65 records were identified through academic database searches, with an additional 10 records sourced through citation chaining and grey literature searches. Following the removal of 3 duplicate entries, 72 records remained and were screened by title and abstract for relevance to the research question.

From this screening, 13 full-text reports were retrieved and assessed for eligibility. Of these, 11 studies were excluded based on the following criteria:

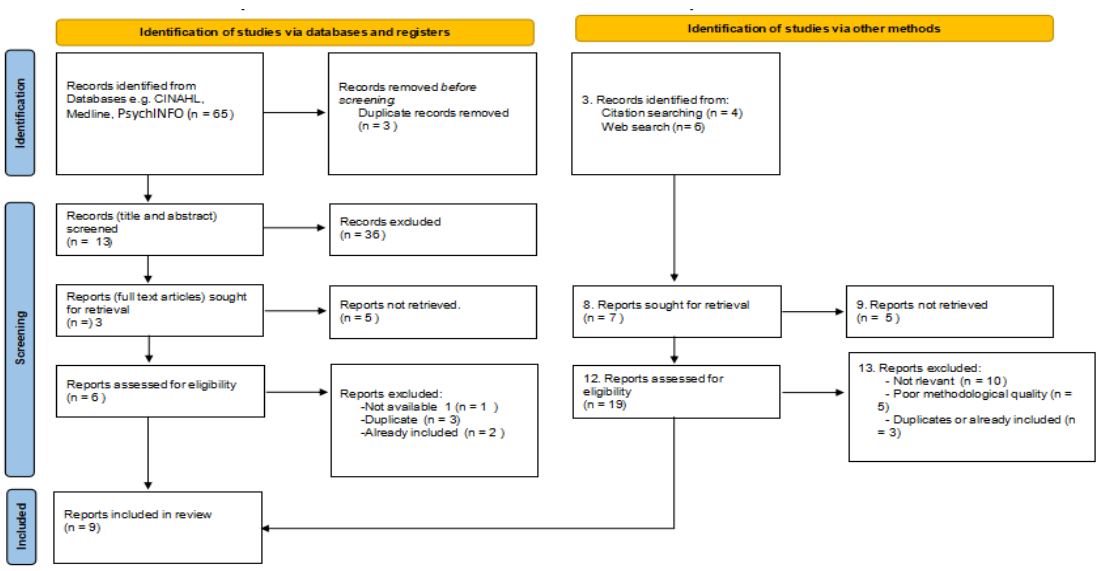
- Not focused on academy-to-professional transition (n = 4)
- Irrelevant population (e.g., recreational players or other sports) (n = 3)
- Lacked sufficient empirical evidence (n = 2)
- Full text unavailable (n = 1)
- Methodological issues (n = 1)

As a result, 9 studies were included in the final synthesis. The selection process is visually summarised in Figure 1 using a PRISMA flow diagram, which outlines the identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion phases of the review.

PRISMA Flow Diagram

I have included a PRISMA flow diagram provides a visual representation of the screening and inclusion process. The flowchart provides a clear outline of each of the stages of the process: identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion so that the readers understand the selection of relevant academic sources during the research study.

Figure 1. PRISMA Flow Diagram of Study Selection Process



3.6 Ethical Considerations

Data collection received ethical approval from the university research ethics committee. A Participant Information Sheet was handed out to the participants detailing the study's purpose, their right to withdraw at any time from the study, and the usage of their data. Informed written consent was obtained before the interviews were conducted with the participants.

Names of participants were substituted with pseudonyms in all transcripts or publication. Role descriptions (some labels, within the study such as “Coach 1”) were made generic as a means of preventing identification. The audio files and transcripts were stored on encrypted devices, accessible only to the researcher. According to ethics, data must be destructed in a safe manner following one year after the conducted study.

3.7 Data Analysis

Thus, Braun and Clarke's (2006) six steps of thematic analysis take data analysis into consideration.

1. Familiarization: It required a transcript of the interviews that were reread and reread to aid immersion in the data again.
2. Generating Initial Codes: Texts that were significant for sampling were hand-coded for a set of codes.
3. Searching for Themes: Gathered coded segments into initial potential themes (e.g., Mental Resilience, Adaptability to Tactics).
4. Reviewing Themes: Commonly, check against the data about how accurately those themes reflected the perspectives of the participants.
5. Defining and Naming Themes: The final themes were named and defined with respect to the research objectives.
6. Producing the Report: These quotes are relevant to synthesize them into analytical narratives.

3.8 Limitations

Researcher bias may have been induced, given that some participants were in informal prior relationships with the researcher. To remedy such an influence on the research, the researcher maintained a reflexive journal throughout the entire research process to record any preconceptions, feelings, and developing insights. This reflexive practice was instrumental in minimizing bias and enabled the researcher to bracket personal views when analyzing the study's data (Siddiqui & Gorard, 2022). This inherently constricted the degree of generalisability and the extent of findings due to a small sample size. The viewpoints captured during the interviews may not be representative of those held by individuals in other football academies across the UK. Moreover, access was limited to staff roles; the inclusion of current players would have enhanced insights into developmental hindrances from the learner's perspective. But it was not feasible as a result of timing and safeguarding complications.

3.9 Chapter Conclusion

The chapter has made a case for a qualitative case-study methodology as an avenue to explore the complex and context-dependent nature of academy player development. The semi-structured interviews generated detailed data, which were systematically analysed using thematic analysis. All ethical protocols were adhered to, and measures against bias as well as limits placed on the sample were explicitly acknowledged. This methodological framework firmly establishes the research and embeds it within a socially rich context, thereby providing a solid base for the analysis presented in the next chapter.

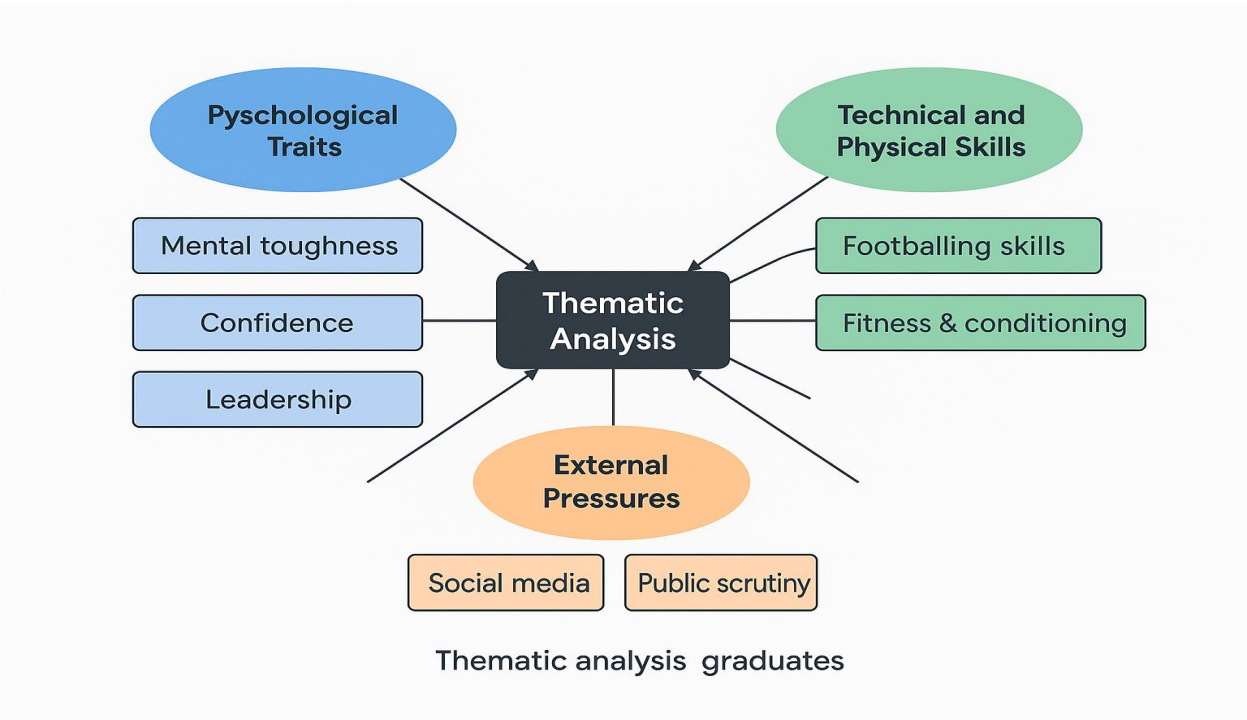
CHAPTER IV: RESULTS AND CRITICAL ANALYSIS

This chapter focuses on the findings from the semi-structured interviews, conducted with coaches, managers, and staff of professional clubs. Using a six-phase thematic approach, three main themes came out of the process: (a) Psychosocial Attributes, (b) Technical and Physical Competencies, and (c) External Pressures and Environmental Influences. The analysis made some comparisons of its own with appropriate literature in order to bring out the critical elements.

4.1 Thematic Analysis Overview

Data from 8 participants were coded using Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step thematic analysis process. NVivo was used for data organization and coding. An initial 187 codes were identified, which were condensed into 12 sub-themes, and finally grouped into the three overarching themes. Figure 1 illustrates the distribution of coded references across themes.

Figure 1: Distribution Thematic Analysis Across Key Themes



4.2 Theme 1: Psychological Attributes (42%)

4.2.1 Mental Toughness and Resilience

Mental Toughness Described by 8 Interviewees as a Non-Negotiable Quality. Participant 4 (Academy Manager) exclaimed:

"You can have all the technical ability in the world, but if a lad can't take it on the chin, he won't last a month in the first team."

This reinforces a finding with which McGlinchey et al. (2022) concur: the released youth players from academies-related causes of failure in their psychological fragility. In the sample, every participant cites one or more of resilient, emotional regulation, bounce-back ability as key assets.

Sub-theme	***Mentioned by***	***Example Quote***
Emotional Regulation	5/5	"He kept calm under pressure, even when benched last minute."
Bounce-back Mentality	3/5	"He came back stronger after every setback."

4.4.2 Confidence and Motivation

All participants communicated about self-beliefs and intrinsic motivation as though they were. The coaches observed how high-performing players would "set their own standards" and go beyond all expectations. Participant 2 said the confidence does not come off as arrogance. Instead, it appeals to knowing roles and executing them as and when required under pressure. The congruency is shown in Fortin-Guichard et al. (2022) where intrinsic motivation was found to be a more worthy predictor for academy selection than technical scores.

4.2.3 Leadership and Communication

One participant stated, "Those who lead by example even in training tend to get noticed faster by senior staff." This highlights the value of a player's mindset and was

typically marked by quiet confidence rather than overt dominance and underscores the need for a careful interpersonal balancing act within the team environment.

4.3 Theme 2: Technical and Physical Competencies (35%)

4.3.1 Footballing Skills and Tactical Awareness

Dribbling, first touch, tactical awareness, and ability to adapt make up the most frequently mentioned technical requirements. Seven out of eight participants mentioned positional awareness as having higher leverage than flair.

Participant 3 "You have to be situationally aware. Its not just what you do with the ball but where you are without it."

These findings support Thoseby et al.'s (2023) conclusions, which underscore the difference made by situational awareness and tactical intelligence in separating elite youth from professionals.

Frequency of Mentioned Technical Skills Table

SKILL	% OF PARTICIPANTS	KEY NOTES
TACTICAL AWARENESS	87.5%	Essential in off-the-ball moments
FIRST TOUCH/CONTROL	75%	High priority in tight situations
PASSING ACCURACY	62.5%	Needed for fast-paced transitions

4.3.2 Fitness and Conditioning

Interviewees indicated performance in peak fitness as an essential criterion to meet senior team standards. 1 Respondent said: "We measure max acceleration in training; very few who really lag behind ever get the nod." This finding is consistent with those reported by Thoseby et. al. (2023). They contrasted the physical outputs of academy players to the professionals in output.

4.4 Theme 3: External Pressures and Environmental Influences (23%)

4.4.1 Social Media and Mental Health

Five participants described the impact of online scrutiny on player well-being. Participant 1 shared, "One of the lads got hammered online for a mistake. He was off for weeks." Observation from Benítez-Sillero et al. (2021) similarly notes the trend for youth players, with performance noticeably dipping after the high media engagement. Players often feel lots of pressure to build a personal brand while still developing on the pitch.

4.4.2 Public Scrutiny and Family Expectations

Half of the participants saw parental pressure, while four participants were concerned with early sponsorships. Participant 5 (Sports Psychologist) mentioned that a '17-year-old coming to training in a £70,000 car' can easily develop a feeling that he or she has already made it. This coincides with Uehara et al.'s (2022) concerns about over-professionalization in youth academies, resulting in the development of inadequate coping strategies.

4.5 Comparison with Existing Literature

The findings align with literature in several critical areas:

Focus Area	Interview Findings	Literature Alignment
Mental Toughness	Critical across all participants	McKay et al. (2024); McGlinchey et al. (2022)
Tactical Awareness	Most valued technical trait	Thoseby et al. (2023); Kite et al. (2021)
Media Pressure	Seen as harmful to mental focus	Benítez-Sillero et al. (2021); Sweeney et al. (2021)
Leadership & Communication	Key for transition to senior team	Barraclough et al. (2024); Saward et al. (2023)

There was one area where the results did not meet expectations, specifically the coach-led tactical instruction. While Ashford et al. (2024) advocated adaptive tactical creativity, a

majority of the interviewees preferred structured compliance with their team systems, showing a gap considering what had been theorized.

Answering the Research Aim and Objectives

Research Question: *What skills and attributes are required by football clubs for academy graduates to transition to first-team football?*

Findings Summary:

- **Psychological Traits**: Mental resilience, confidence, and interpersonal leadership are essential.
- **Technical and Physical Skills**: Tactical awareness, controlled decision-making, and elite fitness levels are key.
- **External Factors**: Social media and external expectations can derail development if unmanaged.

Objectives Addressed:

1. **Analyze psychological traits** – The analysis identifies mental toughness, motivation, and team interaction as critical.
2. **Explore technical and tactical skills** – Tactical intelligence, fitness, and ball control emerged as top priorities.
3. **Evaluate external pressures** – Social and digital pressures were found to significantly affect youth transitions.

4.6 Chapter Conclusion

Technical ability is still important, but psychological resilience and contextual flexibility are as, if not more, important considerations in the progression of academy players.

CHAPTER V: DISCUSSION

5.1 Summary of Key Findings

The thematic analysis revealed that psychological traits, technical skills, and external pressures played a highly significant role in the successful transition of football academy graduates into professional careers. The critical psychological themes included mental toughness, confidence, and leadership. Then, technical factors highlighted that above footballing ability, fitness, and tactical awareness, were also concerned with outside pressure such as social media and public scrutiny, which all significantly affected their emotional stability and performance levels.

5.2 Interpretation of Psychological Traits

The development of certain psychological characteristics was repeated by participants as a key factor for making the bridge from the academy to senior football. Qualities such as resilience and mental toughness were discussed by all interviewed coaches and managers, and such qualities align with McGuigan et al. (2024), who mentioned them as protective factors as opposed to high-performance stress environments in elite football. The players were clear that mental toughness is just as important as talent; without it, even the most gifted individuals could crumble under the scrutiny of coaches, peers, and the media. Confidence was another major theme, often attributed to effective coaching practices, and seen as a precursor to first-team involvement. Interviewees noted that players lacking self-belief tended to pull out under pressure or avoid taking risks in the game. Layton et al. (2023) are in support of this as they propose that psychological confidence directly correlates with assessment of the situation and with performance on the field.

Leadership also rated among the developmental goals. Interviewed coaches felt that future professionals should be able to not only lead themselves but to also motivate their

teammates. In this regard, Lebed (2022) argues that current coaching should focus on helping develop interpersonal skills and leadership ability as an important aspect of a more comprehensive approach of player development.

5.3 Technical Skills

Technical ability is considered a non-negotiable requirement for academy graduates. Interviewees indicated passing precision, retention of first touch, positional sense, and ability to dribble under pressure as parameters that tended to distinguish the would-be professional from the professional. Fitness and conditioning were also emphasized, with interviewees alluding to the high physical demands of football nowadays. This is supported by Thoseby et al. (2023), in that elite youngsters are required to reach professional-level match acceleration demands; hence, maximum physical preparation at academy level is called for. More specifically, while core football skills were prioritized by the participants, there was a necessity for tactical flexibility in playing different systems and structures. Coaches expected that players would understand and execute advanced tactical requirements. This matches the findings of Layton et al. (2023), which stated that English academies also focused on game intelligence rather than just physical development.

5.4 External Pressures

Social media was quoted as a motivator in terms of player performance and, at the same time, a source of anxiety. Interviewees painted a picture of players that concerned themselves way beyond necessary with image, leading to distractions and, in some instances, lower performances as a result. This finding corroborates with those presented by McGlinchey et al. (2022), who discussed the mental health risks associated with the online exposure in particular when a player has been released from an academy.

As it is from fans and the local media, public scrutiny has been said to have an effect on confidence and performance among players. Some interviewees claimed that football players from less media-intense academies may find it easier to adapt and adjust because of less external distraction available to them. This finding is co-honored with Ekren and Anagnostopoulos (2023), which place emphasis on the need to protect athletes against excessive media exposure in youth environments.

5.5 Practical Implications for Football Academies

The study's findings suggest several improvements for football academies:

- **Psychological Support**: Academies should integrate sport psychologists into their development model to help players develop coping strategies for pressure, rejection, and performance anxiety.
- **Leadership Development**: Formal leadership programs or player mentoring systems should be introduced to nurture communication, accountability, and improve emotional intelligence.
- **Enhanced Technical and Tactical Training**: While technical skill development remains essential, academies must evolve to include more context-based, game-realistic tactical sessions.
- **Social Media Education**: Structured education programs on digital responsibility, stress management, and self-esteem should be implemented to help players handle online exposure.

These suggestions mirror calls by McGuigan et al. (2024) for clubs to balance physical and tactical training with broader psychosocial education.

5.6 Comparison with Existing Literature

These findings align with existing peer-reviewed studies. For instance, McGlinchey et al. (2022) who investigated the emotional and resilience-related components upon academy release. Fortin-Guichard et al.'s (2022) conclusion also confirmed that technical competence and game intelligence are probable foremost determinants of academy selection. This study goes a step further to underscore the fact that academy players now must encounter increased social and digital challenges, which previously were not highlighted in earlier research. For instance, the physical and performance data tracking systems were the sole focus of Layton et al. (2023), but the current study brings in the notion of public expectations along with scrutiny from the internet, which has an emotional burden not capable of quantifying. In addition, the findings of the single-case study agree with Lebed's (2022) argument for multi-disciplinary coaching models. It strengthens this view by arguing that development of a player is as much an emotional and psychological issue as it is conditioning.

CHAPTER VI: CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1 Summary of Findings

The present study explored the abilities and qualities needed by football clubs for academy graduates to succeed in their professional fields. Thematic coding of coaches, managers, and academy analysts' interview data identified that psychological characteristics, technical skills, and external pressure are the driving forces. Mental toughness, self-belief, and leadership were considered more relevant to the pressures of first-team football. Technical skills such as passing, understanding, and fitness was still important. Social media and public pressure appeared as significant challenges, with the potential to disrupt emotional stability and hinder performance readiness.

6.2 Implications for Football Academies

Academies will be required to employ an integrative development system alongside body and technical training. Psychological well-being services must be incorporated into the regular training programs. Moreover, offering media training along with emotional resilience to players will be key in enabling them to endure professional football pressure. Technically, training should be difficult and game-like. Players need to be put under different tactical systems and game-like scenarios in a bid to become versatile and self-assured.

6.3 Recommendations for Future Research

Follow-up research would be improved by utilising larger and more varied samples within several clubs and age groups. Longitudinal research following academy players' development to senior level would give even more insight into which characteristics best indicate future success. More focus should be put on the virtual world, assessing the role of social media not only in the psychological makeup of players but also in career development and public image.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Interview transcripts.

Club - Woking football club

Q1: I was just wondering how many years of experience you have with academies or within your club?

A: Yeah. So I've worked at Woking since 2015, so 10 years. Before then, I spent a small amount of time working in a Premier League Academy, but only for a short period. Here at Woking, I've been in the academy for most of my time. I spent five years within the first team as well, with a crossover of about four seasons where I did both roles, and one season where I was solely with the first team. But yeah, 10 years, predominantly in a role as a goalkeeper coach. In the last year, I was promoted to Academy Manager, which is obviously a slightly different role, allowing me to see things from a different perspective.

Q2: Does your club, and do you personally, consider psychological traits when identifying and selecting players for your academy?

A: I think that's probably come in a lot more in recent years, in terms of really wanting to get to know the player. The level that we find ourselves at within the pyramid often means we are trying to get the best players that are physically available to us, particularly those who have come out of higher-level environments like Wimbledon and QPR.

We still have good connections with clubs at a higher level, and when we get a player from that background in for a trial, we generally feel there's a good chance we'll bring them in due to their ability. Last year, we changed our process slightly to introduce prolonged trials, allowing us to really get to know the player.

Its really important for me that we not only understand the player but also get to know their parents. Parents play a huge role in a player's journey, not just in terms of support but also in shaping their behaviors. When players join us at 16, some may feel disappointed if they

Q3: Are there any specific psychological traits or key attributes that you look for in players when assessing their progress?

A: A lot of it is about behaviors—how they interact, how they deal with setbacks or disappointment.

A recent example stands out: we played a team a few weeks ago, and one of their players wanted to come on trial with us. It was a heated, competitive match, and we won. This player took the loss to heart and was clearly very disappointed, which is understandable—we want players who are desperate to improve and succeed.

However, what stood out to me was how he handled that disappointment. Instead of approaching me after the match, he went and sulked in the car. That reaction was telling. Everyone gets disappointed, but it's how you deal with it that matters.

For us, it's about observing these behaviors during training and trials. We look at how players respond to challenges and whether they can handle pressure. Some of these moments are hard to replicate in training, but we try to create a competitive environment to see how players react. If they are better than our current players, that's obviously a great sign technically, but their mindset and behavior are equally important.

Q4: Would you say there's a noticeable difference between players who lack strong resilience and those who handle setbacks well?

A: Yeah, definitely. A good example is squad selection.

When we select a squad, some players will inevitably be left out. How they respond to that is very telling. I look for players who might be disappointed but channel that into motivation—players who think, *"I'll show the coaches and make sure I'm not left out next time."*

On the other hand, there are players who don't take it well. They might go through the motions in training, misbehave, or ignore instructions. Those types of reactions show a lack of resilience.

Sometimes, this happens because players haven't faced much competition before. If they've always been guaranteed to play and suddenly find themselves in a more competitive environment, they struggle. They might have been used to winning or being a key player, but now they're in a setup where playing time isn't guaranteed, and that's a challenge.

Ultimately, football is a team game. Whether you play 90 minutes, 10 minutes, or sit on the bench, the goal is to contribute to the team's success. Some players adapt to that mindset, while others struggle with it.

Q5: It sounds like you and the academy staff are quite focused on the psychological side of the players. Your role is to prepare them for the first team, right?

A: Absolutely. Our role is to prepare players for first-team football. Myself and my assistant manager, James, both have strong first-team experience, so we understand what the next level demands.

We don't want to be too hard on the boys, but at the same time, we can't be too soft either. Some behaviors that they might get away with in the academy won't be tolerated at the next level. For example, if a player isn't selected and they visibly show disappointment, that's okay—to an extent. But they need to channel that frustration in the right way and still contribute to the team.

We try to teach them that side of the game because there will be ups and downs. Players will have to spend time on the bench, and when they get their chance, they need to be ready to perform. For instance, we had a player recently who displayed disappointing behavior while on the bench. We decided not to bring him on as a lesson. He probably doesn't like me much right now, but at the end of the day, professionalism is key.

Football will always test players, especially when things aren't going well. That's when they're really challenged, and how they respond in those moments says a lot about them. From a psychological perspective, it's about getting into the right mindset—supporting the team and staying ready to contribute when needed.

Q6: Moving on to social media influences—do you think the rise of social media has changed how young players handle criticism?

A: Definitely. Social media can be a fantastic tool when used correctly.

For our academy players, it's about giving them exposure and opportunities. We're quite active in sharing team news, goal highlights, and player achievements. It's a great way to showcase what we have and also serves as a marketing and recruitment tool. For the players, it's an opportunity to put themselves in the shop window.

That said, social media can also lead to unhelpful behaviors. We had a 17-year-old player who wasn't selected for a big game, and he posted online: *"Disappointed not to be playing tonight."* To me, that was more about making himself look good—almost suggesting there were external reasons for his non-selection. But in reality, you never see a Premier League player tweeting before a game that they've been left out of the squad. That's not how professionals conduct themselves.

Even though our academy players don't have huge followings yet, their posts still matter. If they reach the first team, where 2,000 to 3,000 people watch every week, fans will take notice. If they lose a game and then post about having a great time out in the evening, that doesn't sit well with supporters.

We want to do more workshops on social media use. It's a powerful tool, and we encourage players to engage with our club's social media because it helps with recruitment and sponsorship. When players share or retweet our content, it increases engagement and benefits the club financially.

The challenge is that young players can sometimes be naïve. They feel like they've already "made it" and don't always think about the consequences of their online presence.

Q7: On that note, how much of an impact do parents have on the psychological pressures players face?

A: Parents can have a huge influence.

Once the boys reach full-time academy level—especially those in our scholarship programs—they need to start becoming more independent. They have to experience their own journey, including the ups and downs that come with it.

Of course, we do hear from parents when their child isn't playing as much as they'd like. But often, these conversations end with a reminder that their son is in the academy to be developed. Some players will progress all the way to the first team, but many won't reach the level expected. That's just the reality of football.

Right now, we have about 25 second-year players approaching the end of their time here. A few will be offered the opportunity to stay, but for the majority, their journey with us will end in the next six to eight weeks. That's when parents need to help their child deal with that realization in the right way.

What we notice is that parents usually speak up when their child isn't playing. But as soon as the player is back in the team, the complaints stop. We understand that every parent wants what's best for their child, but sometimes players need to face challenges on their own.

We've had parents tell us their child is struggling emotionally because they're not playing. While we absolutely want to support our players, that alone isn't a reason for us to change our decisions. If a player wants to reach the first team, they have to be prepared for setbacks. They might train hard every week but still not make the squad for six weeks straight. That's football.

When players encounter those situations, they should be able to look back on previous experiences and think: *"Okay, I've dealt with this before. What did my coaches tell me? What strategies worked?"* That kind of resilience is what will help them in the long run.

Q8: Are you aware of the things that happen outside of the pitch, like issues on social media or problems at home or with friends, which might impact the players on the pitch? How aware are you of those influences?

A: We always have to be conscious of external factors that could impact a player's behavior. With our younger players, who train in the evenings after school, we don't always know what their day has been like. They might have had a great day at school, or a really tough one. They might not have gone to school at all, or they could be dealing with issues at home. For example, if their parents are running late for training, they might feel bad about it.

We try to look at the situation and consider why a player is behaving differently. We encourage parents to flag any concerns with us so we can better understand what's going on in the player's life. Sometimes, behavior issues may stem from personal problems, like the loss of a loved one. We're understanding of that, but at the same time, bad behavior over a prolonged period can't be excused.

We expect a certain level of professionalism and commitment in our training sessions. That's why it's important that, even when players are going through tough times, they still maintain a certain level of focus and behavior. We have 200 players in our academy, and many of them will go through personal challenges. But we need to strike a balance between offering leniency and maintaining the standards expected at the training ground.

Q9: How big of an effect do you think sport specialization has on a player's development? Specifically, when players are focusing on just one sport, like football, at an early age, what impact does that have on their outcome in terms of going pro later on?

A: I think there comes a point when specialization becomes necessary, particularly as players reach a certain age. From the ages of 10 to 11, players don't necessarily need to specialize in football. They can still play a variety of sports, which is important for their overall development and well-being.

But as players get older, particularly as they enter secondary school and approach their mid-teens, they begin to make decisions about their future in football. That's when the focus should shift more toward football, especially if they have a strong desire to make it as a professional.

Personally, I believe it's important for young players to experience other sports before that point. I did when I was younger—played multiple sports, both at school and outside of school. But as players get older, there are only so many hours in a day. If they truly want to progress in football, they'll need to start devoting more time to it.

Q10: Does your club or the coaching staff have any specific training or methods for assessing the mental side of players? How do you know which players are ready to progress to the next stage?

A: Yes, we have certain procedures in place to help assess the mental side of players. Many of our staff complete player welfare courses and safeguarding training. These programs are designed to help us recognize when a player might not be mentally or emotionally ready to perform at their best.

That said, our contact time with players is relatively limited compared to other academies, so we often rely on parents to help flag any concerns. We're aware that players, especially younger ones, are reluctant to show weakness. They might hide emotional struggles, like if they're injured or feeling mentally drained, because they fear it will affect their chances of playing.

It's really important that we spot any mental or emotional issues early on. Sometimes we'll have a quick chat with parents after training if we notice a player seems off or isn't acting like their usual self. While players aren't robots, and won't always perform at their best every day, if a player's behavior or mental state is consistently off, that's when we need to ask more questions and look into what's going on.

Craig Lewington

1. Involvement in Selection Process

Q: What kind of involvement do you have in the selection process for academy players?
A:
My involvement tends to be more observational rather than direct decision-making. I usually oversee trial sessions or come in to observe specific drills and match scenarios. While the primary judgment comes from the coaches who work with these players every day, I'll offer insights on things like work rate, coachability, and attitude—traits that are harder to quantify but incredibly important. I think sometimes a coach's gut feeling about a player's mentality—how they handle pressure or how they respond to feedback—can be as important as their technical ability. Ultimately, it's a collaborative decision, but technical staff have the final say. That said, I've seen players selected not just because of talent, but because they've shown the right behaviours early on—turning up early, helping teammates, even how they speak to staff. Those intangible things matter more than people think.

2. Psychological Traits in Selection

Q: Do you consider psychological traits when identifying or selecting academy players?
A:
Yes, but it depends on the stage of development. When we're first introducing players to the academy, technical skills and physical potential usually take the lead in decision-making. That's partly because we haven't had enough time to get to know the player's character. However, as they move up the age groups—especially from U16s into U18s and U23s—we start to really look at their psychological makeup. Traits like mental toughness, resilience, and self-awareness become key indicators of whether a player is likely to succeed long-term. I've seen technically brilliant players fall away because they couldn't cope with setbacks or competition, while others who maybe weren't as naturally gifted thrived because they were mentally stronger. So yes, it becomes more important the closer they get to a professional contract.

3. Key Psychological Qualities

Q: Are there any key psychological qualities that stand out as important for academy progression?
A:
Definitely. In my experience, three things stand out consistently: self-motivation, emotional regulation, and leadership. Self-motivated players are usually the ones who go the extra mile—doing extras after training, analysing their own performances, asking questions. That kind of internal drive is something you can't teach as easily as technical skills. Emotional regulation is another big one—players need to stay composed under pressure, manage frustration, and bounce back from poor performances. Lastly, leadership doesn't mean being the loudest in the room; it's more about setting the standard, encouraging others, and maintaining a positive mindset. These players tend to elevate the whole group. If we see a young player demonstrating these attributes, they usually stand out, even in a technically strong cohort.

4. Coach Training and Awareness

Q: Are coaches trained to identify and nurture psychological traits in players?
A:
There's no formal training for most of us, unless you go out of your way to study psychology on your own. But that's changing a bit now. Many coaches are starting to understand how vital these psychological elements are. Ten or fifteen years ago, mental health or mindset wasn't even a conversation in most academies. If a player wasn't performing, it was put down to laziness or poor attitude. Now, we're a bit more aware—we ask what's going on behind the scenes. Is there pressure at home? Are they lacking confidence? That sort of thing. But we could definitely do more. A lot of coaches still don't feel confident in applying psychological techniques or identifying traits early. There's a need for more education in this area because psychological development is just as important as technical or physical growth.

5. Use of Sports Psychologists

Q: Do you see the use of sports psychologists becoming more common in academies?
A:
Yes, especially in the top-tier clubs. They've got the resources to embed psychology into their programs with full-time staff. Some even have tailored interventions based on individual player profiles. When my dad was coaching at Crystal Palace, they had a psychologist on-site who worked with the players regularly—whether it was confidence-building, performance anxiety, or just helping players deal with pressure. At our level, we're not quite there yet due to budget constraints, but the intent is there. We try to support players through one-to-one chats or performance reviews, and offer an open-door policy if they're struggling mentally. It's not a replacement for proper psychological support, but it's a step in the right direction. Over time, I'd expect having a sports psych on staff to be as normal as having a strength coach or physio.

6. Social Media Pressures

Q: What are your thoughts on social media and its impact on young players?
A:
It's a huge challenge. Players now are growing up in an environment where everything is public. A bad game doesn't just disappear—it might be clipped, posted, and shared. If a young lad makes a mistake, he could be trending on Twitter the next day. That level of scrutiny can really dent confidence, especially if they read the comments. We try to educate them—remind them that opinions online aren't necessarily accurate or helpful. But they're teenagers, and it's hard to ignore. Some become obsessed with likes or followers, which distracts from their development. I think we have to help them build resilience and give them coping tools. Some players can block it out, but others internalise it. It's definitely part of the modern academy environment, and ignoring it isn't an option.

7. Socioeconomic Factors

Q: Do you take a player's socioeconomic background into account when assessing development or support needs?
A:
Yes, and we have to. You can't treat every player exactly the same off the pitch, because

Appendix 2: Ethics approval and consent forms.

Bournemouth University

Research Ethics Checklist

About Your Checklist	
Ethics ID	62977
Date Created	19/02/2025 16:08:55
Status	Approved
Date Approved	13/03/2025 22:40:59
Risk	High

Researcher Details	
Name	Cal Botterill
Faculty	Faculty of Health & Social Sciences
Status	Undergraduate (BA, BSc)
Course	BSc (Hons) Sport and Exercise Science
Have you received funding to support this research project?	No

Project Details	
Title	Skills and attributes required by football clubs for academy graduates.
Start Date of Project	21/02/2025
End Date of Project	08/05/2025
Proposed Start Date of Data Collection	02/03/2025
Original Supervisor	Tim Rees
Approver	Ethics Programme Team

Summary - no more than 600 words (including detail on background methodology, sample, outcomes, etc.)

In my research, I will explore the psychological traits and key attributes football clubs seek in academy graduates, focusing on talent identification and player development. Through semi-structured interviews, I will gather insights from academy managers, coaches, and scouts working with 13 to 18-year-old male and female players in professional and semi-professional football academies. These participants, directly involved in assessing and developing young talent, will provide firsthand perspectives on the essential skills and characteristics that contribute to a player's progression to the senior level.

My research will examine attributes such as resilience, confidence, adaptability, and mental toughness while considering how evolving club expectations shape player development. By analyzing the perspectives of those responsible for talent selection, this study aims to provide valuable insights into recruitment criteria and the psychological demands placed on academy graduates as they transition into professional football.

To ensure relevance and reliability, participants will be selected based on Population, Intervention, and Outcome Measures criteria. Eligible participants must have at least one year of experience in an academy setting and work with players aged 13 and above who are

officially enrolled in structured football academies. Interviews will focus on psychological aspects within football and will be conducted face-to-face in a semi-structured format to ensure direct engagement. Studies or assessments without communication with players will be excluded.

Filter Question: Does your study involve Human Participants?

Participants	
Describe the number of participants and specify any inclusion/exclusion criteria to be used	
My study plans of interviewing 5 semi-professional/professional football coaches of academies. Inclusion Criteria Participants must be coaches from semi-professional or professional football clubs with academies. Participants must be actively involved in developing or assessing the skills of academy-level players. Coaches must be willing to discuss their insights and experiences related to the skills required by football clubs for academy graduates. Exclusion Criteria Coaches not currently working with semi-professional or professional football clubs with academies. Coaches who are not involved in skill development or assessment of academy-level players. Participants who do not provide informed consent to participate in the interviews.	
Do your participants include minors (under 16)?	No
Are your participants considered adults who are competent to give consent but considered vulnerable?	No
Is a Disclosure and Barring Service (DBS) check required for the research activity?	No

Recruitment	
Please provide details on intended recruitment methods, include copies of any advertisements.	
To recruit participants for my interviews, I am utilizing the following approaches: Direct Email Contact: I have reached out directly to semi-professional and professional football clubs with academies via email. These emails provide an overview of the study, the participant criteria, and an invitation to participate. Coaches who meet the inclusion criteria are encouraged to respond if they are interested. Referral through Networking: In addition to direct contact, I am leveraging my professional network and industry connections. I have also asked colleagues who know managers and coaches at relevant clubs to refer potential participants to me.	
Do you need a Gatekeeper to access your participants?	Yes
Please provide details, including their roles and any relationship between Gatekeepers and participant(s) (e.g. nursing home manager and residents)	
I will be recruiting participants through email outreach to football clubs and academies, with potential gatekeepers being club managers or academy directors who can facilitate access to coaches for interviews.	

Data Collection Activity	
Will the research involve questionnaire/online survey? If yes, don't forget to attach a copy of the questionnaire/survey or sample of questions.	No
Will the research involve interviews? If Yes, don't forget to attach a copy of the interview questions or sample of questions	Yes
Please provide details e.g. where will the interviews take place. Will you be conducting the interviews or someone else?	

I have given the participants the option for an in person interview or online, for example via microsoft teams.	
Will the research involve a focus group? If yes, don't forget to attach a copy of the focus group questions or sample of questions.	No
Will the research involve the collection of audio recordings?	Yes
Will your research involve the collection of photographic materials?	No
Will your research involve the collection of video materials/film?	No
Will any audio recordings (or non-anonymised transcript), photographs, video recordings or film be used in any outputs or otherwise made publicly available?	Yes
If Yes, please provide details.	
The interviews will be audio recorded for transcription purposes using Panopto, ensuring accurate data collection. The recordings will be securely stored on Panopto and only accessible to the research team to maintain participant confidentiality.	
Will the study involve discussions of sensitive topics (e.g. sexual activity, drug use, criminal activity)?	No
Will any drugs, placebos or other substances (e.g. food substances, vitamins) be administered to the participants?	No
Will the study involve invasive, intrusive or potential harmful procedures of any kind?	No
Could your research induce psychological stress or anxiety, cause harm or have negative consequences for the participants or researchers (beyond the risks encountered in normal life)?	Yes
Please provide details and measures taken to minimise risks	
There is minimal risk of psychological stress or anxiety for participants, as the interviews will focus on their experiences and perspectives related to coaching. However, there is still a chance that some questions may trigger discomfort or stress, particularly if they touch on sensitive topics. Participants will be reminded that they can withdraw from the interview at any point without any negative consequences. Efforts will be made to ensure the questions are respectful and non-invasive, with ethical guidelines in place to minimize any potential harm to participants or researchers.	
Will your research involve prolonged or repetitive testing?	No
What are the potential adverse consequences for research participants and how will you minimise them?	
The potential adverse consequences for research participants include minor psychological stress or discomfort if sensitive topics are discussed during the interviews. To minimize these risks, participants will be informed in advance about the nature of the interview and their right to skip any questions they find uncomfortable or to withdraw from the study at any time without penalty. Additionally, I will ensure that the interview environment is respectful and supportive, with clear communication that the participants' well-being is a priority.	

Consent	
Describe the process that you will be using to obtain valid consent for participation in the research activities. If consent is not to be obtained explain why.	
Valid consent will be obtained through a clear and transparent process. Before the interviews, participants will be provided with a Participant Information Sheet, which outlines the purpose of the study, their role, the voluntary nature of participation, and their right to withdraw at any time without consequence. They will also be given an opportunity to ask any questions. Following this, participants will sign a Participant Agreement Form, confirming their informed consent to participate. The form will ensure they understand the nature of the research, how their data will be used, and their rights regarding confidentiality and anonymity.	
Do your participants include adults who lack/may lack capacity to give consent (at any point in the study)?	No

Will it be necessary for participants to take part in your study without their knowledge and consent?	No

Participant Withdrawal

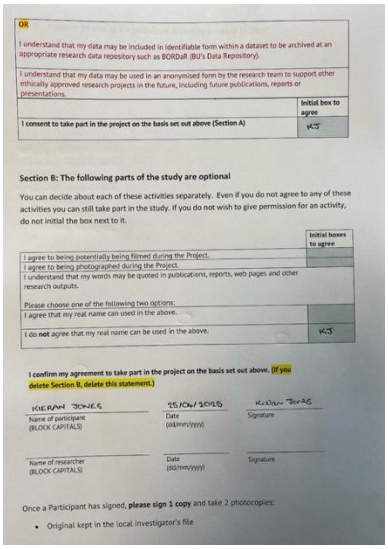
At what point and how will it be possible for participants to exercise their rights to withdraw from the study?	
Participants will have the right to withdraw from the study at any time before their data has been anonymised. If they wish to withdraw, they can contact the research team directly, and their non-anonymised data will be promptly removed from the study. Once the data has been anonymised (i.e., it is no longer linked to the participant in any identifiable way), it will no longer be possible for the participant to withdraw their data.	
If a participant withdraws from the study, what will be done with their data?	
If a participant withdraws from the study, their non-anonymised data will be promptly removed and destroyed to ensure it is no longer part of the research. However, once data has been anonymised and is no longer linked to the participant, it will be considered irreversible and untraceable, and therefore cannot be withdrawn. The participant will be informed of this process, and their right to withdraw data will be made clear to them at the outset of the study.	

Participant Compensation

Will participants receive financial compensation (or course credits) for their participation?	No
Will financial or other inducements (other than reasonable expenses) be offered to participants?	No

Research Data

Will identifiable personal information be collected, i.e. at an individualised level in a form that identifies or could enable identification of the participant?	Yes
Please give details of the types of information to be collected, e.g. personal characteristics, education, work role, opinions or experiences	
Personal characteristics: Name, age, gender, and contact details (e.g., email addresses) for communication and scheduling purposes. Work role: The participants' roles within their respective football academies, including their job title and responsibilities as coaches. Experiences: Opinions and insights related to their coaching practices, experience with academy players, the skills required by football clubs for academy graduates, and any challenges they face in their role. Professional background: Information about their coaching qualifications, years of experience, and the level of teams they work with (e.g., semi-professional or professional clubs).	
Will the personal data collected include any special category data, or any information about actual or alleged criminal activity or criminal convictions which are not already in the public domain?	No
Will the information be anonymised/de-identified at any stage during the study?	Yes
Will research outputs include any identifiable personal information i.e. data at an individualised level in a form which identifies or could enable identification of the individual?	No



OR

I understand that my data may be included in identifiable form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).

I understand that my data may be used in an anonymised form by the research team to support other ethically approved research projects in the future, including future publications, reports or presentations.

	Initial box to agree
I consent to take part in the project on the basis set out above (Section A)	KJ

Section B: The following parts of the study are optional

You can decide about each of these activities separately. Even if you do not agree to any of these activities you can still take part in the study. If you do not wish to give permission for an activity, do not initial the box next to it.

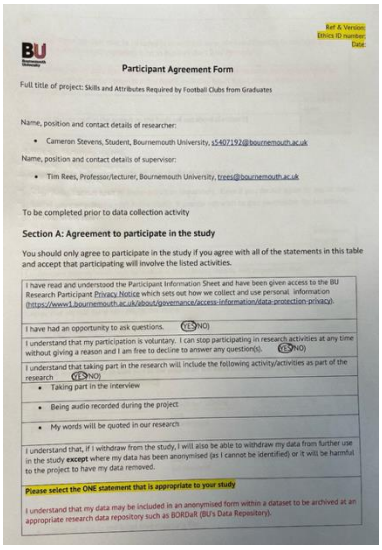
	Initial boxes to agree
I agree to being potentially being filmed during the Project.	
I agree to being photographed during the Project.	
I understand that my words may be quoted in publications, reports, web pages and other research outputs.	
Please choose one of the following two options:	
I agree that my real name can used in the above.	
I do **not** agree that my real name can be used in the above.	KJ

I confirm my agreement to take part in the project on the basis set out above. (If you delete Section B, delete this statement.)

KIERAN JONES	15/04/2025	Kieran Jones
Name of participant (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature
Name of researcher (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature

Once a Participant has signed, **please sign 1 copy** and take 2 photocopies:

- Original kept in the local investigator's file



Ref & Version:
Ethics ID number:
Date:

BU Bournemouth University

Participant Agreement Form

Full title of project: Skills and Attributes Required by Football Clubs from Graduates

Name, position and contact details of researcher:

- Cameron Stevens, Student, Bournemouth University, s5407192@bournemouth.ac.uk

Name, position and contact details of supervisor:

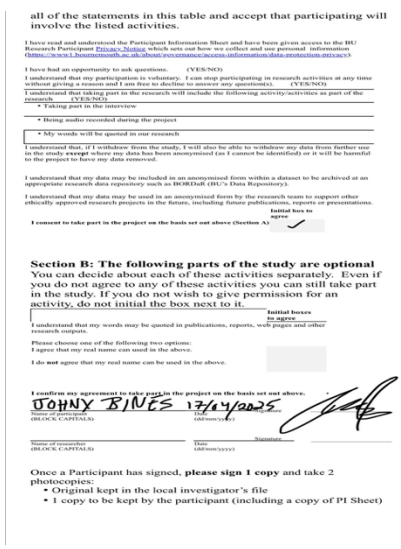
- Tim Rees, Professor/lecturer, Bournemouth University, trees@bournemouth.ac.uk

To be completed prior to data collection activity

Section A: Agreement to participate in the study

You should only agree to participate in the study if you agree with all of the statements in this table and accept that participating will involve the listed activities.

I have read and understood the Participant Information Sheet and have been given access to the BU Research Participant Privacy Notice which sets out how we collect and use personal information (https://www1.bournemouth.ac.uk/about/governance/access-information/data-protection-privacy).
I have had an opportunity to ask questions. (YES/NO)
I understand that my participation is voluntary. I can stop participating in research activities at any time without giving a reason and I am free to decline to answer any question(s). (YES/NO)
I understand that taking part in the research will include the following activity/activities as part of the research (YES/NO) • Taking part in the interview • Being audio recorded during the project • My words will be quoted in our research
I understand that, if I withdraw from the study, I will also be able to withdraw my data from further use in the study **except** where my data has been anonymised (as I cannot be identified) or it will be harmful to the project to have my data removed.
Please select the ONE statement that is appropriate to your study I understand that my data may be included in an anonymised form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).



all of the statements in this table and accept that participating will involve the listed activities.

I have read and understood the Participant Information Sheet and have been given access to the BU Research Participant Privacy Notice which sets out how we collect and use personal information (https://www1.bournemouth.ac.uk/about/governance/access-information/data-protection-privacy).

I have had an opportunity to ask questions. (YES/NO)

I understand that my participation is voluntary. I can stop participating in research activities at any time without giving a reason and I am free to decline to answer any question(s). (YES/NO)

I understand that taking part in the research will include the following activity/activities as part of the research (YES/NO)

- Taking part in the interview
- Being audio recorded during the project
- My words will be quoted in our research

I understand that, if I withdraw from the study, I will also be able to withdraw my data from further use in the study **except** where my data has been anonymised (as I cannot be identified) or it will be harmful to the project to have my data removed.

I understand that my data may be included in an anonymised form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).

I understand that my data may be used in an anonymised form by the research team to support other ethically approved research projects in the future, including future publications, reports or presentations.

	Initial box to agree
I consent to take part in the project on the basis set out above (Section A)	✓

Section B: The following parts of the study are optional

You can decide about each of these activities separately. Even if you do not agree to any of these activities you can still take part in the study. If you do not wish to give permission for an activity, do not initial the box next to it.

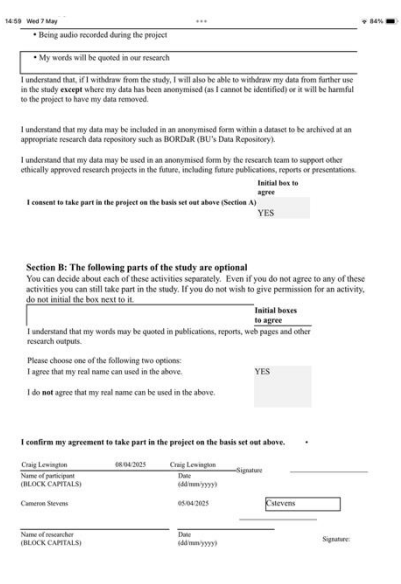
	Initial boxes to agree
I understand that my words may be quoted in publications, reports, web pages and other research outputs.	
Please choose one of the following two options:	
I agree that my real name can used in the above.	
I do **not** agree that my real name can be used in the above.	

I confirm my agreement to take part in the project on the basis set out above.

JOHNY BINES	17/4/2025	
Name of participant (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature
Name of researcher (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature

Once a Participant has signed, **please sign 1 copy** and take 2 photocopies:

- Original kept in the local investigator's file
- 1 copy to be kept by the participant (including a copy of PI Sheet)



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- Being audio recorded during the project
- My words will be quoted in our research

I understand that, if I withdraw from the study, I will also be able to withdraw my data from further use in the study **except** where my data has been anonymised (as I cannot be identified) or it will be harmful to the project to have my data removed.

I understand that my data may be included in an anonymised form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).

I understand that my data may be used in an anonymised form by the research team to support other ethically approved research projects in the future, including future publications, reports or presentations.

	Initial box to agree
I consent to take part in the project on the basis set out above (Section A)	YES

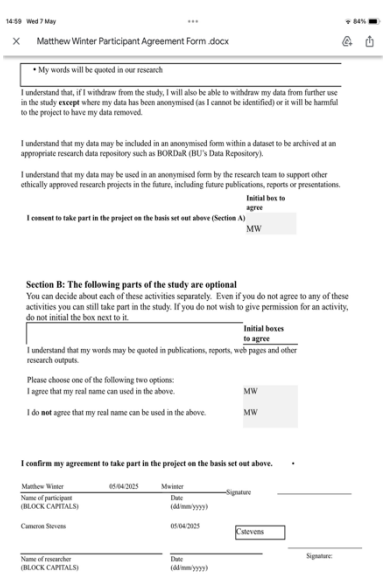
Section B: The following parts of the study are optional

You can decide about each of these activities separately. Even if you do not agree to any of these activities you can still take part in the study. If you do not wish to give permission for an activity, do not initial the box next to it.

	Initial boxes to agree
I understand that my words may be quoted in publications, reports, web pages and other research outputs.	
Please choose one of the following two options:	
I agree that my real name can used in the above.	YES
I do **not** agree that my real name can be used in the above.	

I confirm my agreement to take part in the project on the basis set out above.

Craig Lewington	08/04/2025	Craig Lewington
Name of participant (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature
Cameron Stevens	05/04/2025	Cstevens
Name of researcher (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature:



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Matthew Winter Participant Agreement Form .docx

- My words will be quoted in our research

I understand that, if I withdraw from the study, I will also be able to withdraw my data from further use in the study **except** where my data has been anonymised (as I cannot be identified) or it will be harmful to the project to have my data removed.

I understand that my data may be included in an anonymised form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).

I understand that my data may be used in an anonymised form by the research team to support other ethically approved research projects in the future, including future publications, reports or presentations.

	Initial box to agree
I consent to take part in the project on the basis set out above (Section A)	MW

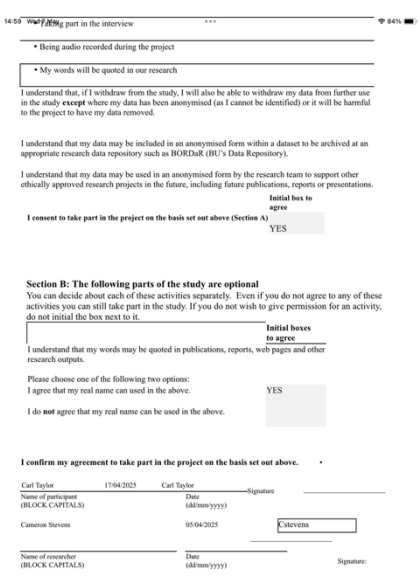
Section B: The following parts of the study are optional

You can decide about each of these activities separately. Even if you do not agree to any of these activities you can still take part in the study. If you do not wish to give permission for an activity, do not initial the box next to it.

	Initial boxes to agree
I understand that my words may be quoted in publications, reports, web pages and other research outputs.	
Please choose one of the following two options:	
I agree that my real name can used in the above.	MW
I do **not** agree that my real name can be used in the above.	MW

I confirm my agreement to take part in the project on the basis set out above.

Matthew Winter	05/04/2025	Mwinter
Name of participant (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature
Cameron Stevens	05/04/2025	Cstevens
Name of researcher (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature:



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- Being audio recorded during the project
- My words will be quoted in our research

I understand that, if I withdraw from the study, I will also be able to withdraw my data from further use in the study **except** where my data has been anonymised (as I cannot be identified) or it will be harmful to the project to have my data removed.

I understand that my data may be included in an anonymised form within a dataset to be archived at an appropriate research data repository such as BORDaR (BU's Data Repository).

I understand that my data may be used in an anonymised form by the research team to support other ethically approved research projects in the future, including future publications, reports or presentations.

	Initial box to agree
I consent to take part in the project on the basis set out above (Section A)	YES

Section B: The following parts of the study are optional

You can decide about each of these activities separately. Even if you do not agree to any of these activities you can still take part in the study. If you do not wish to give permission for an activity, do not initial the box next to it.

	Initial boxes to agree
I understand that my words may be quoted in publications, reports, web pages and other research outputs.	
Please choose one of the following two options:	
I agree that my real name can used in the above.	YES
I do **not** agree that my real name can be used in the above.	

I confirm my agreement to take part in the project on the basis set out above.

Carl Taylor	17/04/2025	Carl Taylor
Name of participant (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature
Cameron Stevens	05/04/2025	Cstevens
Name of researcher (BLOCK CAPITALS)	Date (dd/mm/yyyy)	Signature: